

2026 Comparative Politics Comprehensive Exam

Day 1: Core

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Question

What array of causal drivers are adduced in the literature to account for different political outcomes in regime type, state form or electoral systems (i.e. dictatorship vs democracy; contrasting cleavage structures; electoral systems). How do theorists deploy history and timing in making their arguments?

Introduction

From the peninsula of Gibraltar,¹ one can see land governed by three distinct states: the Kingdom of Spain, the Kingdom of Morocco, and the United Kingdom.² The landscape is visually quite similar; the boundary between Gibraltar and Spain is purely political, and the seven-mile-wide strait is geologically little more than an advanced valley. Yet, each of these lands has experienced dramatically distinct transitions – or lack thereof – from monarchy to democracy. Spain’s development to liberal democracy famously included an extensive fascist dictatorship; the United Kingdom’s gradual progression to the current Westminster System was significantly more gradual; Morocco is still a monarchy today, even if with some modest constitutional restrictions. Why, then, does this one coastal viewpoint offer such a distinct range of political outcomes across a relatively undistinctive physical landscape?

Identifying political and economic deviations across meager physical boundaries is not a novel perspective within political science or the social sciences more generally; Acemoglu & Robinson (2012) famously employ this framework to counter theories of economic dependence on geographical factors in “Why Nations Fail.” Yet, the question is still an intriguing one that has motivated a significant corner of the social sciences, perhaps none more significantly than comparative politics. By Mill’s (1843) “method of difference,” the relatively identical nature of this physical landscape, compared to the significant variation in sociopolitical outcomes, suggests that the causal factors behind regime outcomes must lie elsewhere. If geography alone does not sufficiently explain the distinction between the human-created institutions

¹So long as one’s southward view is not entirely obscured by the titular Rock

²Of which Gibraltar is an “Overseas Territory”

built upon them, then it indeed must be the case that the driving factors are, to a large extent, humanistic themselves.

In this response, I explore the literature's fundamental discussions of the factors driving political outcomes in regime type, state form, and broadly, political institutions. I present three primary causal arguments, each of which is unique in its approach but not mutually exclusive from the others: (1) a state's historical economic composition and structure; (2) the identity-based composition of the constituency, along with the salience of those identity characteristics; and (3) the chronological timing of modernization processes themselves. I further present a relatively – though admittedly not entirely – conflicting counterargument regarding the innate dependency of political outcomes on randomized or exogenous influences, discussing both its limitations and its possible contributions nonetheless. I close by exploring some various empirical strategies that could be used to further our collective perception of these three (or four) causal relationships. **rewrite this – explore existing and present further**

In discussing and evaluating these arguments, I do not intend to provide a definitive weighting of their relative accuracy or value. To do so would be more than I could hope to reasonably accomplish in an entire career, and would almost certainly involve discarding valuable arguments that may indeed be foundational. Yet, I do explore my own perspectives within these frameworks, largely built upon my personal affinity towards rationalist and institutionalist answers. It is our responsibility as social scientists to pursue those narratives which we believe most effectively explain the world around us, and to consider how those mechanisms might be best employed to construct a more effective political future.

An Economic Explanation

One of the field’s driving discussions of political evolution is the role of economic structures and factors. Scholars of this framework broadly posit that the development of contemporary regime types (and the political institutions within them) are a result of the historical amount, distribution, and nature of capital. Yet, the exact ways in which these economic contexts affect long-term political outcomes are quite varied within the literature.

I organize this section into three subsections based on the role of the respective socioeconomic classes: the elites, the middle class, and the poor. A significant component of this literature ties economic structure to ultimate regime type, be that stable democracy, communism, or authoritarianism; as a result, a great deal of this section discusses democratization as a primary dependent variable. Yet, this is far from the only outcome impacted by economic development. As we will see, the evolution of phenomena such as property rights and proportionalist legislatures – both central components of governance – are further influenced by these arrangements.

The Elites: A Power-Sharing Balance

The evolving role of the elites in political development is, to say the least, curious. Historical social orderings generally included an exclusive elite with much greater influence in social, political, and economic affairs than their middle-or-lower-class counterparts. Yet, liberal democracy invokes norms of “representativeness, accountability, equality, and participation” (Lijphart 1991), inherently opposed to the existence of a disproportionately-influential class.

This suggests that an ultimate transition to liberal democracy must involve a transition away from this influence; likewise, an inability to facilitate this transition will likely result in some alternative outcome. There subsequently exist two driving relationships between the elites and political outcomes: the ability of the elite to gain power from the crown, and the decision of an empowered elite to yield additional influence to the lower and middle classes.

Let us first consider the seminal work of Barrington Moore, whose (1966) “Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy” explores (among other topics) the role of the elites in differentiating between democratic, fascist, and communist outcomes. Moore delineates between two general arrangements of the aristocracy: a dependence on the state, or a dependence on the market. If the aristocracy’s wealth was primarily derived from the state – be that sharing in its political rents, employment or appointment to prestigious posts, or similar dependencies – the state would accordingly possess an excess of influence over this class, frequently leading to royal absolutism. This, in turn, largely prevented any transition to even infantile democracy: either the state was powerful enough to retain its absolute authority, or the elites would be empowered to revolt and establish an extractive regime framed by (Boix 2003) as “right-wing authoritarianism.” Conversely, as Moore posits, a power-sharing equilibrium between the crown and the elites was an early prerequisite for later democracy and could facilitate both the peaceful coexistence of the regime and the elites, as well as a peaceful graduation of influence to these aristocrats. Yet, to Moore, these are merely preconditions of further political development, which itself will be motivated by the yeomen and/or the lower classes.

Of course, it is important to consider not just the conditions leading to the enfran-

chisement of the elite, but also the instigating factors which facilitated this development. A common answer is simply informational – that the elites possess privileged information which the state does not. (Ahmed & Stasavage 2020) discuss the emergence of council governance – the first movements away from total executive authority, providing the elites with constrained political authority – as a reflection of informational asymmetry whereby the elites could extract revenue from the land (and the people) much more efficiently than the state. Indeed, they find support for this hypothesis as it pertains to agricultural production, whereby councils were historically more likely to emerge in societies with significant variability in caloric production. In a more contemporary setting, this information “solution” is further adopted by autocrats; (Gandhi & Przeworski 2007) present this dynamic as one reason (of many) for autocrats to employ non-homogenous legislative and bureaucratic institutions. Indeed, the informational explanation is an important one, and we will revisit it when discussing the role of the peasantry.

However, this framework is countered by a broad literature on coercion and “buying off” the elites. In many cases, states faced a meaningful incentive to at least partially enfranchise the elites either to secure economic stability or avoid the aforementioned violence. The most notable contribution to this dynamic is almost certainly (North & Weingast 1989), who explore the expansion of property rights and political constraints following England’s Glorious Revolution. The relative absolutism of the state, they argue, presented two critical obstacles to economic development:

1. Because the state could viably seize or exploit private property, there was limited incentives for the elites to actually invest in private property (and therefore generate capital);

2. Because the state had previously been prone to renege on loans and bonds, there was limited incentives for the elites to invest in the state and its affairs (again primarily through loans and bonds).

At its core, North & Weignast argue, this created a commitment problem that could only be overcome if the state could credibly constrain its future ability to exploit, seize, and renege. Facing this challenge, the state indeed binded itself both through specific guarantees regarding property rights and through a broad transfer of authority from the Crown to the Parliament, whose quasi-elected nature granted some degree of meaningful political influence to the elites. A related line of reasoning indeed explores the extension of the franchise as a means of avoiding revolution from the disenfranchised. Acemoglu et al's aptly named (2000) "Why Did the West Extend The Franchise?", though primarily employed to explain the later inclusion of the middle and lower classes within the political realm, can absolutely be applied to this initial enfranchisement of the wealthy as well: the state (here, the initially-enfranchised body) may avoid revolution by further including these elites. In fact, the credible threat posed by the wealthy (and its resultant impact on authoritarian decay) is not just defined by their capacity for violence, but further by their ability to impact the state's economic structure. In addition to the elite's ability to exploit the aforementioned informational asymmetry, (Boix 2003) stresses the role of the mobility of their own capital in gaining meaningful representation. Under this theory, more mobile capital (technology, trade, etc.) could be easily moved abroad and therefore rid the state of its taxable revenue, while less mobile capital (namely land) did not lend such a threat. This relationship of credible threat is further formalized by (Clark, Golder & Golder 2017)'s exploration of the

“Exit, Voice, or Loyalty” framework, whereby the exploitation of the state is limited by the citizen’s ability to “exit” (in a variety of ways, albeit all costly to the state) the political system.

Now, let us consider the second mechanism discussed above: the elite’s decision to, once empowered, extend enfranchisement to the middle and lower classes. (?) presents this as a central puzzle in democratic development, whereby the holders of power, influence, and wealthy often decided to acquiesce some degree of it. Here, we are orbiting a central theme of the literature on the historical role of the wealthy in contemporary political outcomes: the role of an organized elite in developing (or failing to develop) democratic institutions. (Ziblatt 2017)’s answer to his aforementioned puzzle posits the establishment of an organized conservative movement representing the interests of the elites as a critical factor in a peaceful transition to democracy. This resultant protection, he argues, is a defining factor in achieving either liberal democracy or conversely autocracy. Interestingly, Ziblatt’s argument deviates from the earlier framework of tension between the elites and the state, and instead focuses on tension between the elites and the middle-and-lower classes. If the elites can protect their interests and assets to some degree, a peaceful transition to democracy becomes much less costly for them, and may very well be a tolerable transition. Conversely, if the elites do *not* enjoy this political coordination, the violent seizing of power by the middle-or-lower classes becomes significantly more likely, and with it a reign of left-wing authoritarianism and drastic redistribution (a la (Boix 2003)).

The transition from autocracy to a purely-elite democracy³ is by no means a final transition within political development, but it is a crucially important one: without this first

³More appropriately, a large oligopoly

extension to a restricted democracy, we instead can expect to see a dramatic transformation into various flavors of authoritarianism. Clearly, the ability of the elites to form an organized and credible threat against both the state and the lower classes has a meaningful influence on later political distinctions. To that end, both Ziblatt and Acemoglu & Robinson provide convincing arguments that the decision of the elites is pivotal in democratization. Yet, this is only one piece of the puzzle, and their relevancy above the middle and lower classes is certainly not assured.

The Middle Class: “No Bourgeoisie...”

By far, the most defining work on the role of the middle classes in political development comes from (Moore 1966), who ultimately posits: “No bourgeoisie, no democracy.” Through this lens, and building on similar logic as the role of the elites, the empowerment of the middle and middle-upper classes created an economic vehicle which could secure political enfranchisement from the state. Much of this comes from his delineation of a market-versus-state-dependent aristocracy, further extended to include the middle classes: in the presence of an effective market from which the wealthy and the “yeomen” could extract wealth, opportunities for abuse by the crown became limited, and the market itself grew larger. Yet, it was the transition of these yeomen from collective to private ownership, and in particular the vast expansion of middle-class wealth following the commercialization of agriculture, that in turn fueled further development.

The reason for this transition again involves the credible commitment of the middle classes against both the elites and the state (often at the same time). As (Moore 1966) further

explores, the growing influence of the yeomen – and the resulting tensions between this class and the crown as their wealth grew – ultimately required some form of political concessions. Most prominent among these was the emergence of the modern Parliament, which originated as a “committee of landlords” particularly intended to satisfy this group.⁴ The argument is once again matched closely with Aemoglu et al (2000), whereby the growing power of the middle classes ultimately extracted enfranchisement from the elites in an effort to avoid revolution.

But, just as with the elites, we must not only consider the ability of the middle classes to become empowered, but their willingness to share that power with the lower classes and expand the democratic franchise. Boix (2003) provides a straightforward explanation: the middle class will support a transition to democracy if and only if their income is below average, such that they can expect to be net recipients of democratic redistribution. This may indeed be enough to support an initial transition to full democratization, if the franchise consists of the elites and the middle classes and we hold true the assumption that the middle classes are larger than the elites. Yet, whether or not this new democracy can be maintained is itself a function of a more critical analysis of the role – and position – of the middle class. Such is explored by Iversen & Soskice (2019), who combine this framework with the median voter theorem in order to argue that the sustainability of a democratic regime is dependent on *who* the median voter actually is. This lens suggests that a middle-class median voter will likely support capitalistic endeavors and subsequently self-sustain a liberal democracy with a market economy. Yet, conversely, if the median voter is poor, the transition to democracy may

⁴Note that this necessarily precedes the further expansions of Parliamentary authority as discussed by (North & Weingast 1989), but does present a somewhat intriguing dichotomy. Though the British Parliament’s origins were to satiate the yeomen, a significant amount of influence was held by the elites. Some of this is reflected in the gradual transition of authority from the House of Lords (which directly represented the elite) to the House of Commons (which more broadly represented the yeomen).

not come with a self-enforcing market economy (which itself may threaten the democratic future).

The Lower Classes: Organization and Cross-Class Cooperation

At last, we must consider the distinct role played by the lower, and how its various formations drastically impacted political outcomes. Here, we can first introduce Dahl (1972), who identifies peasantry as the outcome of agrarian societies under hegemony (the alternative being “free farmers” under polyarchy). To understand the role of the lower and peasantry class in the development of modern states, we must subsequently consider what facilitated (or failed to facilitate) this development of inclusiveness, and which of Dahl’s two paths it followed: from closed hegemony to polyarchy, or from closed hegemony to inclusive hegemony.

Let us begin with the first of these questions, which can be broadly characterized as a response to new wealth. Through some form of development – technological progressions, discovery of new resources, or a slew of other possibilities – a society can quickly gain wealth. As Huntington (1968) argues, it is precisely this newfound presence of economic capacity which facilitates a desire for political change; unrest cannot survive in total abject poverty. The impact of this new wealth on the political status of the poor can be clearly seen under two possibilities. First, suppose that the new wealth is broadly enjoyed directly by the poor. Though this process alone is rather rare, the result is a peasantry class who now desire – and can likely extract – political inclusion. More commonly, though, suppose that the poor are largely or entirely excluded from this new wealth. Subsequently, the potential gains of seizing power or inclusion by force become greater, while the costs remain static.

This is precisely the logic presented by Acemoglu & Robinson (Acemoglu & Robinson 2001), who in turn offer a convincing explanation to the second question above (which path of inclusiveness actually occurs). Under this framework, as the wealth held by the elite grows relative to that held by the poor – a calculation influenced both by present welfare and by inequality – the opportunity costs the poor face from revolution become drastically less significant. In such cases, a violent expansion of participation will likely result in Dahl’s “exclusive hegemony,” characterized by high participation but low public contestation. Conversely, in the lack of sufficient motivation for revolution, either slow democratization or general staticity may be expected. Yet, what if the peasantry is sufficiently motivated to pursue change, but not organized enough to launch a meaningful revolution?⁵ Once again, Moore (1966) provides a meaningful explanation: because a powerful peasantry can viably pursue revolution, it is precisely when the peasantry is disorganized or ineffective that a peaceful transition can instead be achieved *if an intentional effort to alleviate this lack of representation is pursued in the meantime*. This again begs Huntington’s (1968) model of political development, in that the order and timing of transition become critically important for whether we can expect peaceful democratization or violent, unpredictable revolution: if the economic growth of the peasantry precedes its political inclusion, we can expect violence, unrest, and inclusive hegemony, but if political development can precede (or even keep pace with) this economic expansion, a more orderly pathway can instead be achieved.

⁵I’m saving much of my collective action literature for tomorrow, but there’s a wealth of opportunity here.

Identity Structures & Cultural Cleavages

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